

FARM TO FIBRE TO FASHION

K.P. Ramasamy, a farmer's son who could study only till high school, set up one of India's largest knitwear garment export businesses which supplies to top global fashion brands like Marks & Spencer, H&M and Primark

By **Vidya S.**

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► **IT WAS THE** late '90s when a young mill worker asked Chairman K.P. Ramasamy if he could help her complete her education, transporting the man back 25 years to when he had to quit college to return to his village because his farmer father could not afford to educate all four sons.

Why shouldn't we educate the young women in our factories interested in studying, he asked his brothers and the rest of the management. A correspondence programme was arranged for around 50 women workers at their mill. They took to it with gusto and cleared their +2 examinations with flying colours.

Beaming, like a proud *appa* (father) that his employees refer to him as, K.P. Ramasamy (KPR) recalls saying in Tamil: "*Inimey ooru varushamum indha maadri padikavekkalam* (Let's do this every year)." Today, some 27,000 women have completed their education, even earning an MBA in many cases, while working at the Coimbatore and Tirupur-based KPR Mill. Some have become nurses in nearby hospitals, a few work at IT firms and many have returned to work at KPR Mill.

"Satisfied employees are better performers. It's a win-win," says the septuagenarian. The motto has held the company in good stead even through the Covid-19 pandemic. When factories across the country sent away their labourers during the nationwide lockdown in 2020, KPR Mill gave its workers a choice: If you stay, we will provide you food, shelter, full salary and entertainment. Each of their 12 factories has a cinema hall, sports



GIVING BACK K.P. Ramasamy, Chairman, KPR Mill

Key Highlights

❶ From modest beginnings in a village near Erode in Tamil Nadu, K.P. Ramasamy and his brothers built KPR Mill into one of the largest, fully integrated knitwear garment exporters in the country which supplies to global brands like Marks & Spencer and H&M

❷ While yarn spinning was its core business, over the past 3-4 years KPR Mill has ramped up focus on apparel production. It debuted its brand of men's premium innerwear and athleisure, FASO, in 2019

❸ A high-school graduate himself, Ramasamy's company has funded the education of 27,000 girls from rural backgrounds while they worked at KPR Mill. Many have even completed MBAs